

Perception Reconsidered

Phil 101 · Day 10

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Where we are

Back to Perception

When I first discussed perception, I noted that it had a problem with illusions, like the checkershadow. And I flagged that one possible move was this:

What's basic isn't *square A is darker than square B*, but rather *square A looks darker to me*.

And I noted the downside of that move was that it meant your starting points were inside your head, and you'd need to find a way out.

Today we'll look at work that accepts that downside.

Russell



Figure 1: Bertrand Russell
(1872-1970)

We're mostly going to be talking about Bertrand Russell, arguably the most important English language philosopher of the last 150 years, maybe more.

Officially Lord Russell, due to a title he inherited from his grandfather, who was Prime Minister in the 1830s.

Won the Nobel Prize for Literature in 1950.

Imprisoned for protesting WWI in 1916, and after that bounced between various academic and non-academic positions, including being hired at CUNY and then having the appointment terminated by courts.

Ibn Sīnā



But we're going to start with a thought experiment from one of the most prominent figures in the golden age of Islamic philosophy, around the 10th and 11th centuries: Ibn Sīnā.

He was based in modern day Iran, and was primarily famous for his medical works, but he was also a massively important philosopher, and an essential part in the chain of influences between ancient Greek sources and medieval Europe.

Figure 2: Ibn Sīnā (Avicenna)

The flying man

Imagine a man created all at once, fully formed.

His eyes are covered. He's suspended in the air, with nothing touching him, and his limbs are held apart so they don't even touch each other.

He perceives nothing at all.

Would he know he exists?

The Flying Man

Ibn Sīnā says that he would. He'd affirm his own existence without affirming that he has a body, or any part of one.

The suggestion is that self-knowledge is in some ways prior to knowledge of the external world.

We'll come back to Ibn Sīnā when we look at what conclusions you can draw from this about what kind of thing the self might be, but for now I just want to introduce the idea that maybe knowledge does start with self-knowledge.

Is anything certain?

i Russell, *The Problems of Philosophy*, ch. 1

Is there any knowledge in the world which is so certain that no reasonable man could doubt it?

Russell's first candidate is the table he's sitting at. It looks oblong, brown and shiny. It feels smooth and cool and hard. Surely he knows that much.

Color

Walk around the table and the color changes. The parts that reflect the light look much brighter than the rest. In the dark there's no color at all.

i Russell

But the other colours which appear under other conditions have just as good a right to be considered real; and therefore, to avoid favouritism, we are compelled to deny that, in itself, the table has any one particular colour.

Shape

We say the table is rectangular. But from almost anywhere you stand, it looks as if it has two acute angles and two obtuse ones.

i Russell

The 'real' shape is not what we see; it is something inferred from what we see.

Even texture ends up being tricky on this approach. The table looks smooth, but under a microscope it's all hills and valleys.

Russell's vocabulary

i Russell

Let us give the name of 'sense-data' to the things that are immediately known in sensation: such things as colours, sounds, smells, hardnesses, roughnesses, and so on.

Sensation

The experience of being immediately aware of something.

Sense-data

What you're immediately aware of: the colors, shapes and textures.

Physical object

The table, if there is one.

Two questions

Once the table and what you see have come apart, Russell says two questions arise.

i Russell

- (1) Is there a real table at all?
- (2) If so, what sort of object can it be?

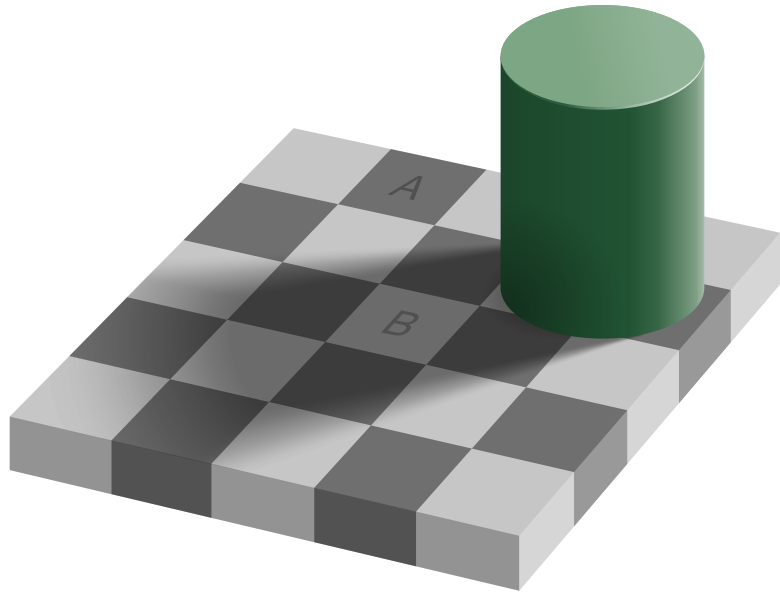
We'll come back to illusion in a second, but note that Russell here is really not stressing **illusion**.

He isn't saying that you are frequently, or ever, *tricked* by the apparent angles of the table.

He's stressing **apparent variation**.

The argument from illusion

A quick question (POLL)



Is there anything here that is darker?

- A. Yes, square A is darker
- B. Yes, something in my experience is darker, though neither square is
- C. No, nothing is darker. A merely looks darker.

Argument from illusion

Russell's reasoning has been tidied up into what's nowadays called the **argument from illusion**. Here's how it starts.

1. In an illusion, it seems to you that something is darker, although square A isn't darker than B.
2. Whenever it seems to you that something is darker, there really is something darker that you're directly aware of.
3. So in an illusion, what you're directly aware of isn't the square.

Premise 2 has been called the **Phenomenal Principle**, and it's somewhat controversial.

Argument from illusion (cont.)

OK fine, something weird happens with illusions. Does this affect normal life? The second part of the argument says that it does.

4. Illusions and ordinary perceptions can be exactly alike from the inside, so the same account should cover both.
5. So even when things go right, what you're directly aware of isn't the square.

Conclusion: you *a/ways* directly perceive sense-data, not ordinary objects.

The veil

If all you're ever directly aware of is sense-data, then the world sits behind them, like a scene behind a curtain.

Everything you believe about tables, people and planets becomes an inference from patches of color to their causes.

For comparison, think about how you learn about a baseball game by watching TV. Intuitively, you learn about the baseball game not by seeing *it*, but by seeing a screen it is showing on.

For Russell, and other sense-data theorists, that's the normal case; sense-data are playing on the private screen in your head.

Shared evidence (or not)

Your sense-data are yours.

Nobody else can be aware of them, and it's not even obvious how anyone else can know what they are like.

We'll come back to how troubling this is next Thursday.

But to get a sense of it, think how differently the same show can look on different TVs, or even on one TV with different settings.

It's possible, indeed likely, that there is just as much variation in how the world looks to each of us as there is variation between TVs.

Shared Evidence (or not)

When we all look at the same table, we aren't sharing evidence.

Each of us has our own private appearances, and we can only compare our reports about them.

That turns *all* shared evidence into testimony about private objects.

Strange objects

What are these strange private objects?

The darker patch isn't on the board, where the two squares are the same shade.

Is it in your head? Nothing in your head is that shade of grey either. (At least, I don't think it is. But they do call it grey matter? Maybe I should be careful here before I make claims about neurology.)

Just to flag something that we're going to fret about a bit, is there anything *physical*, anything that ordinary science discusses, that has that shade?

It isn't clear; this view might suggest that ordinary perception involves things outside the domain of physical science.

An escape hatch: Reject premise 2

One natural spot to push at the argument is the Phenomenal Principle: the claim that if something *seems* darker, there must *be* something darker.

Two big rivals to the sense-data theory both deny it.

Representation

On the first view, experience works like language. Your experience **represents** square A as darker.

A false sentence saying A is darker doesn't need a darker thing to exist. It's just false.

Likewise an illusion doesn't need a darker object. It's an experience that gets things wrong. It's not true that anything A-related *is* darker than anything B-related, any more than the letter A has to be darker than the letter B in the sentence "A is darker than B".

Naive realism

On the second view, you're simply aware of the square itself, and **looking darker** is something the square does in that light, to a viewer like you.

Russell got really close to that view, although it wasn't what he intended.

The color, he wrote, is "something depending upon the table and the spectator and the way the light falls on the table."

A naive realist agrees, and concludes that looks are relations between the thing, the light and you.

There don't need to be private objects grounding these looks any more than there need to be private directional objects grounding the fact that I'm north of the table and you're west of it.

What you voted on

B is the Phenomenal Principle, premise 2. If something seems darker, then something darker is there.

Once you buy that, a lot of the escape routes from the argument close off.

C denies the Phenomenal Principle, and both these rivals agree that it's false.

They aren't the only rivals, but they are useful to start with.

A I think is a straight-up denial that things like objective shades exist; not an unheard of position, but pretty radical. This might have been Democritus's position: "by convention sweet and by convention bitter, by convention hot, by convention cold, by convention color; but in reality atoms and void".

There are other views, including ones that deny that there is any content to how the picture looks, but those are enough options for now.

This week

- ▶ Module Quiz 1, on Lectures 1 to 9, is due on Sunday.
- ▶ Short Answer 1 is written in section next week.

Tuesday

Today asked what experience is *of*.

Tuesday asks what it's *like*, and asking how much experience differs between very different individuals, and between very different kinds of individuals.